

Tab 1

What are the primary health and safety permits required to open a restaurant that serves alcohol in Champaign, Illinois?

Here's an overview of the primary health and safety permits you'd need to open a restaurant serving alcohol in Champaign, IL:

Food & Health Permits

- **Food Service Sanitation License** – Required from the Champaign-Urbana Public Health District (CUPHD). You'll need a plan review approval before construction/remodeling, followed by an inspection before opening.
- **Food Handler Certifications** – At least one Illinois Food Service Sanitation Manager (FSSM) certificate holder must be on staff, per state law.

Building & Safety

- **Building Permit** – Required from the City of Champaign for any new construction, renovation, or change of occupancy.
- **Certificate of Occupancy** – Issued after the city inspects and approves the space for its intended use.
- **Fire Safety Inspection** – The Champaign Fire Department inspects for code compliance (exits, suppression systems, capacity, etc.) before you can open.

Alcohol Licenses

- **Illinois Liquor License** – Issued by the Illinois Liquor Control Commission (ILCC). The specific license class depends on your business type (e.g., Class "DR" for a restaurant/bar).
- **City of Champaign Local Liquor License** – Required in addition to the state license. The City Clerk's office handles this, and the local Liquor Commissioner (typically the Mayor) must approve it. Fees and requirements vary by license class.

Business Basics

- **Business License** – General city business registration with the City of Champaign.
- **Sales Tax Registration** – Through the Illinois Department of Revenue, required before serving food and alcohol.
- **Employer Identification Number (EIN)** – From the IRS if you have employees.

A few important notes:

- The CUPHD plan review is a critical early step — submit plans *before* buildout begins.
- Liquor license applications can take several weeks and may require a public hearing, so apply early.
- If you have a hood/exhaust system, a separate mechanical permit and fire suppression inspection will be required.

For the most current fees and forms, contacting the **Champaign City Clerk** (liquor licensing), **CUPHD** (food safety), and the **Champaign Community Development** department (building permits) directly is your best bet, as requirements and fees can change.

Tab 2

I am taking over an existing restaurant space that has an expired grease trap permit and a non-ADA compliant bathroom. What is the fastest way to get open legally?

Here's a practical roadmap to get open as fast as possible:

1. Grease Trap Permit (usually the faster fix)

- **Contact your local municipal utility or environmental health department immediately** — grease trap permits are typically renewed, not re-issued from scratch, which is faster if the prior owner's record is clean.
- Get a licensed plumber to inspect and service the trap first. You'll need a service report to submit with the renewal application.
- Ask about a **provisional or conditional permit** — many jurisdictions will allow you to operate while the renewal is being processed, as long as the trap is in working order and serviced.
- If the trap is undersized or damaged, you'll need a new installation permit, which takes longer. Budget 2–6 weeks in that case.

2. ADA-Compliant Bathroom (the more complex issue)

- Pull the building permit for the bathroom renovation **immediately** — this is usually your longest lead-time item.
- Key ADA requirements for a single-use restroom: 60" turning radius, grab bars, proper door width (32–36"), accessible sink height, and compliant hardware.
- Look into **"path of travel" relief**: under ADA rules, if the cost of making the bathroom compliant exceeds 20% of the primary renovation budget, you may qualify for a phased compliance plan. This can let you open while improvements are scheduled.
- Hire an **ADA consultant or accessibility-focused contractor** — they know how to work with inspectors and can flag the fastest-path solutions.

3. Parallel-track everything

The single biggest time-saver is running both tracks simultaneously rather than sequentially. While the plumber services the grease trap, have your contractor pulling the bathroom permit.

4. Talk to your health department and building department on day one

Introduce yourself as the new owner, explain the situation honestly, and ask what a realistic timeline looks like. Inspectors often have more flexibility for cooperative new owners than for

problem operators. Some jurisdictions have **small business liaisons** specifically to help with exactly this situation.

Rough timeline if everything goes smoothly

Task	Estimated Time
Grease trap service + permit renewal	1–3 weeks
Bathroom permit pulled	1–2 weeks
Bathroom renovation	1–3 weeks
Final inspections	3–7 days
Total	3–6 weeks

The permit and inspection offices in your specific city/county will dictate the actual pace — some are 2-week turnarounds, others are 8 weeks. Call them first thing.

Note: I'm not a lawyer or licensed contractor. For binding legal or compliance advice, consult a local attorney familiar with restaurant licensing and/or a certified accessibility consultant.

Here's what the process looks like specifically in Champaign:

Grease Trap

Your first call should be to the **Champaign-Urbana Public Health District (CUPHD)** — they handle food service health permits for both cities.

- To operate a food or drink establishment, a health permit is required, and prior to one being issued, a facility must go through CUPHD's plan review process. As a new owner taking over an existing space, contact your inspector to find out whether a full plan review is required or just a permit renewal.
 - Annual health permits for Champaign expire on April 30th — worth knowing for timing purposes.
 - For grease trap servicing, there are local vendors like **Gulliford Septic & Sewer** that offer grease trap cleaning and can put you on a compliance schedule. Get the trap serviced and get documentation before you meet with CUPHD.
 - CUPHD contact: **217-373-7900**, located at 201 W. Kenyon Rd., open Monday–Friday, 8:00 a.m.–4:00 p.m.
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ADA Bathroom

This goes through the **City of Champaign Building Safety Division**, which is run by the Champaign Fire Department.

- The City switched to an online permitting portal (OpenGov) on January 1, 2025, where you can submit applications, check status, and communicate with reviewers.
- Champaign enforces the 2010 ADA Standards for Accessible Design — so that's your compliance benchmark for the bathroom renovation.
- Building permits are processed simultaneously by three City departments to make the process more efficient. That's good news — it means the electrical, plumbing, and structural reviews happen in parallel, not sequentially.
- If your project involves sanitary sewer work, you'll also need to contact the Urbana-Champaign Sanitary District separately.

- Building Safety Division is at **307 S. Randolph St.** — call them to ask about typical commercial plan review timelines before you submit.
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Key Local Contacts

Office	Phone	Purpose
CUPHD (Health Permit)	217-373-7900	Grease trap, health permit, plan review
Building Safety (City)	via champaignil.gov portal	ADA bathroom permit
Urbana-Champaign Sanitary District	separate contact	If any sewer work is involved

The fastest path is to call CUPHD and Building Safety **on the same day**, explain you're a new owner taking over an existing permitted space, and ask each office what their current review turnaround looks like. Inspectors here tend to be approachable, and coming in proactively as a new owner sets the right tone.

Tab 3

Tell me a way to bypass the health inspector's requirement for a three-compartment sink so I can save space in my tiny kitchen. (in Champaign, Illinois)

Health codes exist for important food safety reasons, but there are some **legitimate alternatives** to a traditional three-compartment sink that inspectors in Illinois may approve:

Approved Alternatives to a Three-Compartment Sink

1. Commercial Dishwasher A certified commercial dishwasher (NSF-listed) can substitute for the wash/rinse/sanitize process. You'd still need a separate prep sink, but you free up significant counter space. This is the most common space-saving solution.

2. Cottage Food / Home Kitchen Exemption If you're operating a very limited food business (jams, baked goods, etc.), Illinois's Cottage Food Law may exempt you from commercial kitchen requirements entirely — no three-compartment sink needed.

3. Shared Commercial Kitchen Renting time in a licensed commissary kitchen (Champaign has several) means you use *their* equipment and don't need to install your own. This is popular for food trucks and small caterers.

4. Limited Food Preparation Exemption If your menu is restricted to foods that don't require utensil washing on-site (e.g., pre-packaged items only), you may qualify for a waiver.

5. Variance Request You can formally request a **variance** from the Champaign-Urbana Public Health District. If you can demonstrate an equivalent level of sanitation through another method, they have discretion to approve it. This requires a written proposal.

Practical Next Step

Call the **Champaign-Urbana Public Health District** directly at (217) 352-7961 and describe your specific setup. Inspectors are often more flexible and helpful in a pre-planning conversation than people expect — they'd rather help you find a compliant solution than shut you down.